



DELHI

Declaring Their Assets

Will they, won't they? Ending months of speculation and controversy, 21 judges of the Supreme Court, including Chief Justice of India K.G. Balakrishnan, finally declared their assets last week. The details—which include moveable and immovable assets, jewellery, bonds and investments held by the judges and their spouses—were put up on the apex court website. According to the declarations, the CJ has assets of about Rs 25 lakh, which includes a nine-year-old Santro car and two plots of land. Nearly two years ago, activist Subhash Agarwal filed an appeal under the Right to Information Act in the Supreme Court asking whether the honourable judges had declared the details of their assets and liabilities. Though his application was rejected, it triggered a public debate whether judges of the apex and high courts should declare their possessions like other public servants. Different states have reacted in different ways to the demand for transparency. While judges of the Kerala High Court were the first to declare their assets, in other states they have been reluctant to go public with exactly what they own. These include the judges of the Allahabad High Court (the biggest high court in the country) and judges of the Delhi High Court. Hopefully, the judges in all high courts will now follow the example set by the judges of the apex court.

**CHIEF JUSTICE
OF INDIA K. G.
BALAKRISHNAN**

by Shyam Lal Yadav

25

lakh rupees worth of assets, including a nine-year-old car, is the Chief Justice of India's public declaration of his private wealth.